

Almost nobody in this book was stupid. That is the whole difficulty: they were the people best placed to know.

Eight days before the crash of 1929, the leading economist in America announced that stock prices had reached a permanently high plateau. Eight years before Kitty Hawk, the most eminent physicist in Britain explained that heavier-than-air flight was impossible. Neither man was a fool. Both were reasoning carefully from what they knew.

A hundred and twenty predictions that were wrong, made by people who were in an unusually good position to be right. Each one comes with what actually happened, and with the part that transfers: what the mistake was made of.

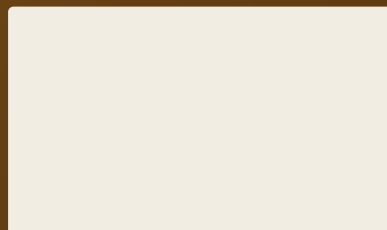
The same shapes come round again. A cost that prices only the interesting part. A model fitted to a stretch of history that did not contain the event. An opponent treated as an object rather than as somebody who will respond. A number chosen to win a vote and then believed. And, over and over, the one person who said so in advance, in writing, and was overruled.

“Heavier-than-air flying machines are impossible.”

Lord Kelvin, 1895

WHAT THE ERROR WAS MADE OF Kelvin was not guessing. He was the most eminent physicist in Britain, and he was reasoning from the power-to-weight ratios of the engines he knew about, which were steam.

120 PREDICTIONS · 12 CHAPTERS · 4 PARTS



Confident and Wrong

A HISTORY OF CERTAINTY

Confident and Wrong

A hundred and twenty predictions made by people who knew better, and what the mistake was made of.

120 PREDICTIONS · 12 CHAPTERS